

purchase a particular product by offering an incentive, not to initiate alley walks and recycling center runs among housewives. Certainly there were times I bought extra Kraft Macaroni and Cheese specifically for the crayon offer or boxes of Fruit by the Foot for the personalized pencils, but for the majority of refunds, I simply went to my files to fulfill the offer. For many years, they made it easy for anyone willing to save their trash to participate in the offers on a grand scale. When Crest rewarded free AT&T gift certificates in exchange for UPCs from toothpaste boxes, I was able to pay my entire phone bill for several months with the boxes I'd already filed in my cabinet. I ordered a dozen strands of M&M lights with the candy bags a neighbor had saved for me. And every year, for several years in a row, Hershey outfitted my family with free T-shirts, thanks to the candy bar wrappers we'd collected from garbage cans. Yes, the years between 1970 and 1990 were a heyday for refunders. However, it wasn't long before companies caught on and began requesting dated cash register receipts or specially marked proofs of purchase.

